“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Antya-līlā

Chapter 1

The Testing of Rūpa Gosvāmī at Siddha-bakula

(translated from the Bengali for this edition)

1 I offer obeisance to the Lord, Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya, whose mercy makes the lame cross a mountain and the mute recite the scriptures.

2 I am blind, and on this difficult path my feet keep slipping. May the saints give me the staff of their mercy and be my support.

3 Śrī Rūpa, Sanātana, Raghunātha Bhaṭṭa, Śrī Jīva, Gopāla Bhaṭṭa and Raghunātha Dāsa —

4 I bow at the feet of these six gurus, by whose grace obstacles are destroyed and all one longs for is fulfilled.

5 All glory to the merciful Śrī Śrī Rādhā and Madana-mohana! I am lame and dull of mind, and They are my only refuge; Their lotus feet are all I have.

6 I remember the beautiful Rādhā and Śrīla Govindadeva, seated on a throne in a beautiful temple of jewels beneath a wish-fulfilling tree in the radiant forest of Vṛndāvana, served by Their dearest companions.

7 May the beautiful Śrī Gopīnātha, who begins the sweet rāsa dance, be our good fortune. Standing on the bank by Vaṁśīvaṭa, He draws the gopīs to Himself with the sounds of His flute.

8 Glory, glory to Śrī Caitanya! Glory to Nityānanda! Glory to Advaitacandra, and glory to all the devotees of Gaura!

9 I have described the Madhya-līlā in brief. Now, O devotees, hear something of the Antya-līlā.

10 Within the Madhya-līlā, in the earlier part of this book, I have briefly described the *sūtras* (summaries) of the Antya-līlā.

11 I am overcome by old age, and knowing that death is near, I have described some *sūtras* of the Antya-līlā.

12 Following the *sūtras* written earlier in the book, I now describe in detail what I have not written before.

13 When the Lord returned from Vṛndāvana to Nīlācala, Svarūpa Gosāñi sent word of it to Gauḍa.

14 Hearing this, Śacī and all the devotees rejoiced, and together they set out for Nīlācala.

15 The devotees of Kulīnagrāma, all the residents of Khaṇḍa and the Ācārya came and joined Śivānanda.

16 Śivānanda paid the tolls for everyone at the river crossings, looked after them all and found them places to stay.

17 A dog was traveling with Śivānanda. He fed it and looked after it as he took it along.

18 One day, at a river crossing, an Oriya boatman would not let the dog into his boat.

19 The dog was left behind, and Śivānanda grew sad. He paid ten *paṇas* of cowries and had the dog taken across.

20 One day Śivānanda was detained at a tollgate, and his servant forgot to give the dog its rice.

21 Returning at night, at mealtime Śivānanda asked his servant, “Has the dog been given its rice?”

22 Hearing that the dog had not been fed, he grew sad and sent ten men to search for it.

23 The men searched but could not find the dog, and they all came back. In his sorrow Śivānanda fasted.

24 In the morning they searched for the dog but found it nowhere, and all the Vaiṣṇavas were astonished.

25 Anxious at heart, they all traveled on to Nīlācala, and Mahāprabhu met them all as before.

26 He took them all for *darśana* of Jagannātha, and then Mahāprabhu took His meal together with them.

27 As before, the Lord sent everyone to their lodgings, and the next day they all came to Him.

28 When they arrived, they all saw that very dog sitting a short distance from the Lord.

29 The Lord was tossing it coconut pulp, His *prasāda*, and smiling He said, “Say ‘Rāma,’ ‘Kṛṣṇa,’ ‘Hari’!”

30 The dog ate the pulp and said “Kṛṣṇa” again and again. Seeing this, the people were filled with wonder.

31 When Śivānanda saw the dog, he bowed down before it and humbly begged forgiveness for his offense.

32 From the next day no one saw the dog again: it had attained a perfected body and gone to Vaikuṇṭha.

33 Such are the divine pastimes of the son of Śacī: He made even a dog say “Kṛṣṇa,” and so He delivered it.

34 Meanwhile, by the Lord’s order, Rūpa had come to Vṛndāvana, and the wish arose in him to write a drama on Kṛṣṇa’s pastimes.

35 He began the drama in Vṛndāvana and wrote its invocation, the *nāndī* verse, right there.

36 As he traveled, he pondered the plot of the drama, and he began to set some of it down in a draft (*kaḍacā*).

37 In this way the two brothers came to Gauḍa, and there Anupama left this world on the bank of the Gaṅgā.

38 Rūpa Gosāñi set out for the Lord; his heart longed to see Him.

39 Because of Anupama he was delayed, and when he came to join the devotees, he could not find them.

40 In the land of Orissa there is a village called Satyabhāmā-pura. He rested there for one night.

41 That night he saw in a dream a woman of divine beauty. She came before him and graciously gave him an order:

42 “Compose a separate drama about me. By my mercy the drama will be extraordinary.”

43 After this dream Rūpa Gosāñi reflected: “Satyabhāmā orders me to write a separate drama.

44 I have joined the pastimes of Vraja and of the cities in one plot. Now I shall divide them into two parts and compose them.”

45 Absorbed in these thoughts, he soon reached Nīlācala and went to stay at Haridāsa’s dwelling.

46 Haridāsa Ṭhākura received him with great kindness and said, “The Lord told me that you would come.”

47 Every day, after seeing the *upala-bhoga* offering, the Lord would come to see Haridāsa. Now He arrived unexpectedly.

48 “Rūpa is offering You obeisance,” said Haridāsa. The Lord greeted Haridāsa and then embraced Rūpa.

49 The Lord sat down together with Haridāsa and Rūpa. He asked about their welfare, and for some time they spoke together of Kṛṣṇa (*iṣṭa-goṣṭhī*).

50 When the Lord asked for news of Sanātana, Rūpa said, “I did not meet him.

51 I came by the route along the Gaṅgā, and he by the main road, so we did not meet.

52 At Prayāga I heard that he had gone to Vṛndāvana." Then he told the Lord that Anupama had left this world on the bank of the Gaṅgā.

53 The Lord gave Rūpa lodging there and left. Then the devotees who accompanied the Lord came to meet Rūpa.

54 The next day Mahāprabhu came with all the devotees and kindly introduced Rūpa to them all.

55 Rūpa bowed at the feet of all of them, and they all kindly embraced him.

56 The Lord said, "Advaita and Nityānanda, both of You, give Rūpa Your mercy with all Your heart.

57 By the mercy of You both, may he gain the power to describe devotion to Kṛṣṇa and its *rasas*."

58 All the Lord's devotees, from Gauḍa and from Orissa, came to hold Rūpa dear.

59 Every day the Lord came to meet Rūpa, and whatever *prasāda* He received in the temple He gave to the two of them.

60 After speaking with them of Kṛṣṇa for a while, the Lord would leave to perform His midday duties.

61 Such was the Lord's practice every day, and receiving the Lord's mercy, Rūpa felt boundless joy.

62 With the devotees the Lord cleansed the Guṇḍicā temple; then He came to Āiṭoṭā and held a feast in the garden there.

63 All the devotees were eating *prasāda* and calling out “Hari!” Seeing this, Haridāsa and Rūpa were delighted.

64 Through Govinda they received the remnants of the Lord’s meal, and the two of them, intoxicated with love, began to dance.

65 Another day the Lord met Rūpa and sat with him. The Lord, the crown jewel of the omniscient, began to speak:

66 “Do not take Kṛṣṇa out of Vraja. Kṛṣṇa never leaves Vraja to go anywhere else.

67 ‘The Kṛṣṇa born in the Yadu dynasty is another; but He who is the son of the king of the cowherds never leaves Vṛndāvana to go anywhere.’” (Yāmala, quoted in Laghu-bhāgavatāmṛta, 1.5.461)

68 Saying this, Mahāprabhu left for His midday duties, and Rūpa Gosāñi was somewhat astonished.

69 “Satyabhāmā ordered me to write a separate drama, and now I understand that the Lord too has ordered me to write a separate drama.

70 Before, the two dramas were composed together. Now I shall divide them in two and arrange their plots.

71 Two *nāndī* verses, two prologues (*prastāvanā*), two plots: after careful thought I shall write them separately.”

72 At the Ratha-yātrā Rūpa had *darśana* of Jagannātha and saw the Lord dancing and singing *kīrtana* before the chariot.

73 Hearing the verse the Lord recited as He danced, Śrī Rūpa Gosāñi took up its meaning and composed a verse on the spot.

74 I have described all this before; still I shall tell something of it briefly.

75 During *kīrtana* the Lord would recite an ordinary verse, and no one knew why He recited it.

76 Svarūpa Gosāñi alone knew the meaning of the verse, and he would sing songs that matched it for the Lord to relish.

77 Rūpa Gosāñi understood the Lord's intent and composed a verse with that meaning, a verse that the Lord loved.

78 "He who stole My heart in My girlhood is now My lord. These are the same moonlit nights of Caitra, and the same full breezes blow from the kadamba groves, fragrant with blossoming *mālatī*. I too am the same. Yet My heart yearns for Our play of love there, beneath the *vetasī* trees on the bank of the Revā." (Padyāvalī, 386)

79 "My dear companion, this is that same beloved Kṛṣṇa, met again at Kurukṣetra, and I am that same Rādhā; this is the same joy of Our union. Yet My heart longs for the forest on the bank of the Kālindī, which delights in the sweet fifth note of His flute playing in its depths." (Padyāvalī, 387)

80 Rūpa Gosāñi wrote the verse on a palm leaf, tucked it into the thatched roof and went to bathe in the sea.

81 Just then the Lord came to see him. Noticing the verse in the thatch, the Lord began to read it.

82 As He read the verse, the Lord was overwhelmed with joy and love. Just then Rūpa Gosāñi returned from his bath.

83 Seeing the Lord, Rūpa fell flat in the courtyard to offer obeisance. The Lord gave him an affectionate slap and said,

84 “How did you know My hidden heart?” And saying this, He embraced Rūpa tightly.

85 The Lord took the verse and showed it to Svarūpa, and to test Svarūpa He asked him,

86 “How did Rūpa know what is in My heart?” Svarūpa said, “I know: You Yourself have shown him mercy.

87 Otherwise no one could know this meaning. I infer that You showed him mercy earlier.”

88 The Lord said, “He met Me at Prayāga, and knowing him to be a worthy recipient, I gave him My mercy.

89 Then I infused him with power and instructed him. You too should teach him the finer points of *rasa*.”

90 Svarūpa said, “As soon as I saw this verse, I knew that You had shown him mercy.

91 ‘The cause of a fruit is inferred from the fruit itself.’ (a maxim of Nyāya)

92 ‘We eat the tips of the stalks of the golden lotuses that grow in the heavenly Gaṅgā, and so our bodies have gained a beauty that matches our food: an effect takes on the qualities of its cause.’” (Naiṣadhīya, 3.17)

93 After staying for the Cāturmāsya, the Vaiṣṇavas returned to Gauḍa, but Rūpa Gosāñi remained at Mahāprabhu’s feet.

94 One day, as Rūpa was writing his drama, Mahāprabhu arrived unexpectedly.

95 In reverent haste the two of them rose and fell flat before Him. The Lord embraced them both and sat down.

96 “What book are you writing?” He asked, and He took up one leaf. Seeing the handwriting, the Lord was pleased at heart.

97 Śrī Rūpa’s letters were like rows of pearls, and the Lord, delighted, praised the handwriting.

98 On that leaf the Lord saw a verse, and as soon as He read it, He was overwhelmed with love.

99 “I do not know with how many nectars the two syllables ‘Kṛṣ-ṇa’ were born. When they dance on the lips, they make one long for many mouths; when they sprout in the hollows of the ears, they make one yearn for millions of ears; and when they come as a companion into the courtyard of the mind, they conquer the workings of all the senses.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.15)

100 Hearing the verse, Haridāsa was jubilant, and he began to dance, praising its meaning.

101 I know the glory of Kṛṣṇa’s name from the scriptures and from the lips of saints, but nowhere have I heard of such sweetness in the name.

102 Then Mahāprabhu embraced them both and went to the sea to perform His midday duties.

103–104 The next day, after seeing Jagannātha, Mahāprabhu set out together with Sārvabhauma, Rāmānanda, Svarūpa and others, and they all

came to meet Śrī Rūpa. On the way the Lord began to tell them all about Rūpa's qualities.

105 Reciting the two verses, the Lord felt great joy, and He praised the qualities of His devotee as though He had five mouths.

106 To test Sārvabhauma and Rāmānanda, He began to describe Śrī Rūpa's qualities to them both.

107 It is the Lord's nature not to hold His devotee's offenses against him. He regards a little service as great, and His grace goes so far that He gives Himself.

108 "This Lord Puruṣottama, pure in mind by nature, does not see even the grave offenses of His servant; He accepts even the slightest service as many times greater; and even toward those who slander Him He shows no ill will." (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 2.1.138)

109 When the two of them saw that the Lord had come with His devotees, they fell flat before Him and worshipped their feet.

110 Together with His devotees the Lord greeted the two of them, and then He sat down with the devotees on the raised platform (*piṇḍā*).

111 Rūpa and Haridāsa both sat at the foot of the platform; in front of everyone they would not climb up onto the seats.

112 The Lord ordered, "Rūpa, recite the earlier verse." But Rūpa, overcome with shyness, would not recite it and kept silent.

113 Then Svarūpa Gosāñi recited that verse, and on hearing it everyone was filled with wonder.

114 “My dear companion, this is that same beloved Kṛṣṇa, met again at Kurukṣetra, and I am that same Rādhā; this is the same joy of Our union. Yet My heart longs for the forest on the bank of the Kālindī, which delights in the sweet fifth note of His flute playing in its depths.” (Padyāvalī, 387)

115 Rāmānanda Rāya and Sārvabhauma Bhaṭṭācārya said, “Without Your grace, how could he know this heart of Yours?

116 Earlier You infused Your power into me and spoke conclusive truths whose end even Brahmā cannot find.

117 From this we know that he received Your grace earlier: without it, no one could put Your heart into words.”

118 The Lord said, “Rūpa, recite the verse from your play that takes away people’s sorrow and grief when they hear it.”

119 When the Lord had ordered him again and again, Rūpa began to recite that verse:

120 “When it dances in the mouth, it makes one long for many mouths; when it crowds into the hollows of the ears, it awakens a desire for millions of ears; when it appears in the courtyard of the heart, it overpowers the activity of all the senses. I do not know of how many nectars the two syllables ‘Kṛṣ-ṇa’ have been made.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.15)

121 All the assembled devotees and Rāmānanda Rāya were filled with bliss and wonder on hearing the verse.

122 All said, “We have heard of the boundless glory of the Name, but no one else has described such sweetness.”

123 Rāya said, “What book are you composing, I wonder, that holds within it this mine of conclusive truths?”

124 Svarūpa said, “To compose a play on Kṛṣṇa’s pastimes, describing together His pastimes in Vraja and in the cities,

125 he had begun it; now, having received the Lord’s order, he has divided it into two plays:

126 *Vidagdha-mādhava* and *Lalita-mādhava*. In both plays the *rasa* of love is wondrous throughout.”

127 Rāya said, “Recite the *nāndī* verse — let us hear it.” Accepting the Lord’s order, Śrī Rūpa recited the verse:

128 “May the *śikhariṇī* of Hari’s pastimes take away your thirst, born on the rough road of worldly existence that breeds suffering on every side. It humbles the pride of sweetness even of the moon’s nectar, and it is perfumed with the camphor of the love of Rādhā and Her companions.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.1)

129 Rāya said, “Recite the description of your worshipful Deity.” But Rūpa, hesitating before the Lord, would not recite it.

130 The Lord said, “Why don’t you recite it? Why this hesitation and shyness? Let the assembly of Vaiṣṇavas hear the fruit of your book.”

131 When Rūpa Gosāñi then recited the verse, the Lord, on hearing it, said, “This is excessive praise.”

132 “May the Lord Hari, the son of Śacī, illumined by a mass of lustre more beautiful than gold, ever shine in the inmost cave of your hearts. Out of His mercy He has descended in the age of Kali to bestow what had not

been given for a very long time — the treasure of devotion to Himself, rich in the most exalted, radiant *ujjvala-rasa*.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.2)

133 On hearing the verse, all the devotees said, “By letting us hear this verse you have blessed us all.”

134 Rāya asked, “In which prologue (*āmukha*) do the characters enter?” Rūpa said, “In the one called *pravartaka*: they enter when the fitting time has come.”

135 “An entrance brought on by the arrival of the fitting time is called *pravartaka*.” (Nāṭaka-candrikā, 12)

136 “The spring season has come, in which Paurṇamāsī, with a hidden purpose, will unite at night that complete Lord, filled with fresh love, with lovely Rādhā for Their play.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.10)[1]

137 Rāya said, “Tell us the *prarocanā* and the rest — let us hear.” Rūpa said, “I take Mahāprabhu’s desire to hear as the *prarocanā*.”

138 “An assembly of devotees whose intelligence knows no obstruction, radiant by nature, has gathered; this composition about the Friend of the cowherd women has blossomed with fine qualities; and the ground in the heart of the Vṛndāvana forest has become the arena for the dance. I think the mass of merit of people like me has now ripened and is unfolding.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.8)

139 “O wise ones, though this composition has been brought forth by me, insignificant by nature, it is full of Hari’s qualities and will fulfil your aims. Does not fire, kindled by rubbing wood even by a Pulinda, remove the inner impurity of bars of gold?” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.6)

140 Rāya said, “Tell us now the causes from which love arises: the first attraction (*pūrvānurāga*), its transformations (*vikāra*), its actions (*ceṣṭā*), and the love letter (*kāma-likhana*).”

141 Śrī Rūpa Gosāñi explained everything in order, and the Lord’s devotees were amazed to hear it.

142 “Merely hearing the syllables of one man’s name, ‘Kṛṣṇa’, I lost My senses; the sound of another’s flute brings on a stream of deep madness; and this one, with the soft lustre of a rain cloud, has been fixed in My mind ever since I saw Him in a picture. Alas, shame on Me! I have come to love three men. I think it is better for Me to die.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.9)

143 “Friend, this pain in Rādhā’s heart is very hard to cure: even the treatment one undertakes for it ends only in disgrace.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.8)

144 “O beautiful one, taking the form of a painted picture, You dwell in My house; and wherever I flee in fright, there You forcibly block My way.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.33)[2]

145 “On seeing a bit of peacock feather before Her, She at once begins to tremble; at the sight of *guñjā* berries She cries aloud again and again, in tears. I do not know what new *graha*, a possessing power, has entered the field of this girl’s heart, producing the wonder of an unprecedented play of dancing.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.15)

146 “If Kṛṣṇa is merciless to Me, how is that your fault? Do not weep in vain. Only perform this last rite for Me, friend: lay the creepers of My arms on the trunk of a *tamāla* tree, so that this body of Mine may stay unmoving in the forest of Vṛndāvana forever.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.47)

147 Rāya said, “Tell us now the nature of *bhāva*.” Rūpa answered that *bhāva* directed toward Kṛṣṇa is like this:

148 “O beautiful one, when love for Nanda’s son awakens in someone’s heart, its pains drive out the pride that fresh *kālakūṭa* poison takes in its sting, and its outpouring of joys humbles the boast of nectar in its sweetness. Its crooked and sweet powers are clearly known to that person alone.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.18)

149 Rāya said, “Tell us the characteristics of natural love.” Rūpa Gosāñi answered that the very nature of *prema* is natural:

150 “In this love, praise makes one show indifference yet pains the heart; even blame, bearing the charm of a jest, gives delight; it neither wanes because of any fault nor grows because of any virtue. So plays the working of a certain natural love.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 5.4)

151 “Hearing of My cruelty, moon-faced Rādhā will break the sprout of Her love, make Her afflicted heart steady, and probably turn away from Me; or else, terrified of the bow of wicked Kāma, She will give up Her life. Alas, in My folly I have uprooted the tender creeper of desire that was about to bear fruit!” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.40)

152 “Friend, in the hope of the happiness of His embrace I cast off My great shyness before the elders; I tormented you, My dearest friends, dearer to Me than life; I disregarded even the great *dharma* that chaste women follow. Shame on My steadiness, that though He neglects Me, I, sinful as I am, still live!” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.41)

153 “Playing at home in our natural childlike simplicity, we did not know in the least what was good or bad. How was it proper to bring us into such a helpless state? And how is it just for You now to take the path of indifference?” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.46)

154 “Stained by inner suffering, we are surely going today to the city of Yama, and still He does not give up His laughter so fond of heaps of deceit. Ah, wise Rādhikā, how could such great love arise in You for this rake of the cowherd village, so full of deep guile?” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.37)

155 “O ocean Kṛṣṇa, the river Rādhikā, full of fresh *rasa*, has left far behind on her way the tree of her husband that stood beside her, broken through the bridge of *dharma*, and swiftly crossed the mountain of her elders, and she has reached You. Why, then, do You turn her away with the waves of Your words?” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 3.9)

156 Rāya said, “How have you described Vṛndāvana, the sound of the flute, Kṛṣṇa, and Rādhikā?

157 Tell us, for hearing your poetry fills one with wonder.” Bowing down, Rūpa Gosāñi recited them in order:

158 “This forest of Vṛndā, where swarms of bees are held captive again and again by the sweet, fragrant flow of nectar from masses of mango buds, and which sways in the gentle breezes from the sandalwood mountain (Malaya), swells My incomparable bliss.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.23)

159 “Vṛndāvana is surrounded by divine creepers; the creepers bear tips sparkling with flowers; the flowers are filled with intoxicated bees; and the bees sing songs that captivate the ear.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.24)

160 “Here the bees are singing, there it is cool with the soft breeze; here the creepers dance, there drifts the pure fragrance of *mallikā* flowers; and there the juice of rows of pomegranates flows in streams. This Vṛndāvana delights all the senses.” (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.31)

161 “Inlaid at both ends with dark gems for the breadth of three thumbs, its adjoining parts set with red gems, and in the middle made of pure gold

shining with diamonds — this auspicious flute of Hari's play sports in His hand." (Vidagdha-mādhava, 3.1)

162 "O flute, you were born of good bamboo — of a good family; you dwell in the hand of Puruṣottama; and you are straight by birth. Then from what guru, friend, did you receive this crooked initiation into the mantra that bewilders all the gopīs?" (Vidagdha-mādhava, 5.17)

163 "Friend flute, you are full of large holes; you are light, very hard, knotty, and sapless. Yet by what fruition of merit do you constantly enjoy the embrace of Hari's hand, dense with the bliss of His kisses?" (Vidagdha-mādhava, 4.7)

164 "The sound of the flute stopped the clouds, filled Tumburu with wonder again and again, drew Sanandana and the other sages away from their meditation, and astonished Brahmā; it stirred Bali with waves of eagerness, set the king of serpents spinning, pierced the wall of the shell of the universe, and spread in all directions." (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.27)

165 "Here is Hari, shining: the beauty of His eyes has humbled the lustre of the finest white lotus; His yellow garments mock the glow of fresh *kuṅkuma*; His forest adornments have subdued all regard for divine dress; and His body is radiant with a lustre more captivating than an emerald." (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.17)

166 "Friend, O beautiful one, accept this supreme bliss who stands before you: His right foot rests against His lower shin, His waist is slightly bent, His neck is turned to the side and held still, the corners of His eyes glance sidelong; on His budlike lips He holds the flute, touched by His restless fingers, and His brows move like bees." (Lalita-mādhava, 4.27)

167 "O fair-faced one, what unprecedented Viśvakarmā is this before us? With flashes of the sharp chisel of His long sidelong glances He splits the

heaps of stones of noble women's *dharma*, and at the same time, with countless emeralds, builds chambers in the cowherd village." (Lalita-mādhava, 1.52)

168 "Friend, a certain fresh youth is shining — the moon of the dynasty of the king of Vraja, the lustre of whose body mocks the pride of clusters of great sapphires. Glory to the sound of His flute, which delights in breaking the bolts of the knotted sashes of crowds of steadfast noble women!" (Lalita-mādhava, 1.49)

169 "The beauty of Her eyes forcibly swallows the fresh blue lotus; the radiance of Her face surpasses a forest of blooming lotuses; the lustre of Her body brings even gold to a painful state. Indescribably wondrous is the beauty of Rādhā as it plays." (Vidagdha-mādhava, 1.32)

170 "Alas, the moon loses its beauty by day, and the lotus at nightfall. With what, then, can the face of My beloved, always shining with beauty, be compared?" (Vidagdha-mādhava, 5.20)

171 "The sidelong glance of that girl with lovely lashes, whose cheeks smile with waves of the *rasa* of joy and whose creeper-brows dance like Kāma's bow, bearing the charm of an intoxicated, softly humming, darting bee, has stung this heart of Mine." (Vidagdha-mādhava, 2.5)

172 Rāya said, "Your poetry is a stream of nectar. Now tell us the *nāndī* of the second play."

173 Rūpa said, "Where are you, radiant like the sun, and what am I? An insignificant creature, like the glimmer of a firefly.

174 Even to open my mouth before you is impudence." Saying this, he recited the *nāndī* verse:

175 “May the full moon of Mukunda’s fame give you joy — the moon that saddens the *cakravāka* birds, the breasts of the fair-eyed wives of the gods’ enemies, and the lotuses, their faces, while it forever delights the *cakora* birds, all His friends.” (Lalita-mādhava, 1.1)

176 Rāya asked, “Now recite the second *nāndī*.” Feeling hesitant, Rūpa began to recite:

177 “Rising over the earth, He pours out abundantly the nectar of love for Himself; He has accepted the position of supreme king of the twice-born; He dispels the mass of darkness and has won the minds of the whole world. May that moon named Śacī’s son bestow some blessing upon me.” (Lalita-mādhava, 1.3)

178 On hearing it, the Lord felt joy within, yet outwardly He said something with a show of anger:

179 “Your words about the *rasa* of Kṛṣṇa are an ocean of nectar. Why have you put into it this drop of the alkali of false praise?”[3]

180 Rāya said, “Rūpa’s poetry is a flood of nectar, and into it he has put a drop of camphor.”

181 The Lord said, “Rāya, you are delighted by this, but I am ashamed even to hear it, and people will laugh.”

182 Rāya said, “People are happy to hear it, for an auspicious invocation is the remembrance of one’s cherished Deity.”

183 Rāya asked, “In which part do the characters enter?” Then Rūpa Gosāñi explained the particulars:

184 “Kalānidhi (Kṛṣṇa, the moon), dancing on the stage, will slay the king of the Kirātas (Kaṁsa) and in due time take the hand of virtuous Tārā (Rādhā).” (Lalita-mādhava, 1.11)

185 “This prologue is called *udghātyaka*; it is a part of the *vīthī*. To speak of it before you is a wave of impudence.

186 ‘When people, to grasp the meaning of words whose sense is unclear, join them with other words, it is called *udghātyaka*.’” (Sāhitya-darpaṇa, 6.289)

187 Rāya said, “Tell us further about the particular parts.” Śrī Rūpa indicated a few of them briefly:

188 “The mass of dust points to Hari; the darkness ahead unites Him (with the gopīs). The path of the fair-eyed girls of Vraja is not revealed even to the all-seeing Śruti.” (Lalita-mādhava, 1.23)

189 “Glory to that skilful messenger, entrusted with the purpose — the soft melody born of the finest bamboo — who overcomes Rādhā’s shyness and draws Her from home to the forest!” (Lalita-mādhava, 1.24)

190 “Friend, who is this fearless youth, with the lustre of a rain cloud and the sporting grace of an intoxicated elephant? From where has He come to the land of Vraja? Ah, with the thieves of His restless, roving glances He is plundering the wealth of My composure from the treasury of My heart!” (Lalita-mādhava, 2.11)

191 “She who is the celestial river in which the king-elephant of My mind sports, the light of the bright autumn moon for the *cakora* birds of My eyes, and a lovely string of stars adorning the sky of My chest — that Rādhikā I have attained through My lofty desires.” (Lalita-mādhava, 2.10)

192 Hearing this, Rāya spoke at the Lord's feet, praising Rūpa's poetry as if with a thousand mouths:

193 "This is not poetry — it is a stream of nectar. All its dramatic features are the essence of conclusive truth.

194 This wondrous description is love artfully unfolded; hearing it, the mind and ears whirl in bliss.

195 'What use is a poet's poetry or an archer's arrow which, lodged in another's heart, does not make his head spin?'

196 Without Your power, such words could not come from a living being. I infer that You have given him power and are making him speak."

197 The Lord said, "He met Me at Prayāga, and his qualities pleased My heart.

198 Sweet is the subject of his poetry, and it is rich in ornaments. Without such poetry *rasa* cannot be made known.

199 All of you, be merciful and give him this blessing: that he may unceasingly describe the *rasa* of love in the pastimes of Vraja.

200 His elder brother is named Sanātana; there is no learned man on earth equal to him.

201 His renunciation of worldly things is just like yours, and humility, detachment, and learning abide in him.

202 I gave these two brothers power and sent them to Vṛndāvana to set forth the scriptures of devotion."

203 Rāya said, “You are the Lord: whatever You wish to do, You can make even a wooden puppet dance.

204 All the *rasas* You proclaimed through my mouth I now see in his writings.

205 Out of mercy for Your devotees You wish to reveal the *rasa* of Vraja; whoever You empower to do it will bring the whole world under Your sway.”

206 Then Mahāprabhu embraced Rūpa and had him bow at everyone’s feet.

207 Advaita, Nityānanda, and all the other devotees mercifully embraced Rūpa.

208 Seeing the Lord’s mercy to Rūpa and Rūpa’s good qualities, everyone was amazed.

209 Then Mahāprabhu left with all the devotees, and Haridāsa Ṭhākura embraced Rūpa.

210 Haridāsa said, “There is no limit to your good fortune. Who can know the greatness of all that you have described?”

211 Śrī Rūpa said, “I know nothing at all. I speak only the words that Mahāprabhu makes me speak.

212 ‘Though I am wretched, I have been set to this work by His prompting within my heart. I worship the lotus feet of that Hari, Śrī Caitanya-deva.’” (Bhakti-rasāmṛta-sindhu, 1.1.2)

213 In this way the two of them delighted in talks about Kṛṣṇa, and Rūpa happily passed his time in Haridāsa’s company.

214 When all the Lord's devotees had stayed for four months, the Lord bade them farewell, and they returned to Gauḍa.

215 Śrī Rūpa stayed at the Lord's feet in Nīlādri and joyfully watched the Dola-yātrā with Him.

216 When the Dola-yātrā was over, the Lord gave Rūpa His order; bestowing much grace on him, He infused him with power.

217 "Go to Vṛndāvana and stay there. Send Sanātana here once.

218 Go to Vraja and set forth the scriptures of *rasa*, and there make known all the lost holy places.

219 Spread the service of Kṛṣṇa and devotion in *rasa*. I too shall go there once to see it."

220 Saying this, the Lord embraced him, and Rūpa Gosāñi placed the Lord's feet on his head.

221 Taking leave of the Lord's devotees, he went back to Vṛndāvana by the road through Gauḍa.

222 Thus I have told of Rūpa's second meeting with the Lord. Whoever hears this attains the feet of Caitanya.

223 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. The verse has a second sense: on the full-moon night (*paurṇamāsī*) the night unites the moon, its lord, with the star Rādhā (Viśākhā). The principal sense refers to Bhagavatī Paurṇamāsī, who unites Śrī Kṛṣṇa with Rādhikā (*Anubhāṣya*, *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*). Before the verse the edition prints, in verse type, *tasyodāharaṇaṁ yathā* (“Its example:”) — a linking phrase that is not part of the verse. ↩
2. The verse is in Prakrit (in Sanskrit, *dhṛtvā praticchanda-guṇaṁ sundara mama mandire tvaṁ vasasi…*). *Mandira* here means “house”: in this love letter Rādhā says that Kṛṣṇa, in the form of a painted picture, lives in Her house (*Anubhāṣya*, *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*). ↩
3. So in the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition: *kṛṣṇa-rasa-vākya*, “words about the *rasa* of Kṛṣṇa”; other editions read *kṛṣṇa-rasa-kāvya*, “poetry”. ↩